Polo the Little Penguin and the First Swim



A bedtime story for ages 4–7



At the very bottom of the world, where the snow sparkles blue under the moon, there lived a little penguin chick named Polo. Polo had soft grey fluff and feet as orange as a sunset. He loved to waddle and slide on his tummy down the snowy hills. But there was one thing Polo had never done.



Polo had never been swimming. Every evening, the grown-up penguins hopped off the ice into the deep blue sea. Polo watched from the edge, his toes curled tight. The water looked so big, so deep, and so very dark. "Not today," he whispered, and waddled back to his mama.



One evening, the sky turned pink and gold, and the first stars came out. Mama nudged Polo gently toward the water's edge. "Just come and look," she said. Polo took one small step, then another. His heart went thump, thump, thump.



At the edge of the ice, Polo peeked down. Beneath the surface, something silver darted and twinkled. It was Finn, a tiny silver fish, swimming round in circles. "Hello up there!" bubbled Finn. "The water is full of twinkles. Come and see!"



Just then — sploosh! — a round grey head popped out of the water, and two bright eyes blinked up at Polo. It was Suki, a seal pup, laughing as the waves rocked her. "The sea is warm as a hug," she sang. "Come in, Polo!"



Polo took a deep breath and hopped — splash! Cold water rushed over his soft fluff. A wave tickled his nose, and he sneezed a great big penguin sneeze. "Achoo!" He scrambled back onto the ice, shivering and dripping. "Too cold! Too big!" he cried.



Mama wrapped Polo in her warm, soft feathers. "I remember my first swim," she said. "My flippers shook, just like yours. So I took one small hop. Just one." Polo snuggled close. The moon had risen, and the water shimmered with silver light. It did not look quite so dark now.



Polo stood up. He waddled to the edge. One small hop... two small hops... and — SPLASH! He was in! The water held him up like a soft, blue blanket. His flippers paddled. His feet kicked. And Polo was swimming!



Finn darted around him in silver spirals. Suki twirled and rolled, and Polo twirled too. They dived and bobbed up again, laughing, under the green ribbons of the aurora. Polo's heart was not thumping now. It was singing.



When the stars were high, Mama called, "Time to come home, little swimmer." Polo waddled up onto the ice and shook himself, and the droplets flew off like tiny stars. He snuggled into Mama's warm feathers, and his eyes grew heavy. The sea whispered, and Polo dreamed of silver fish and twirling seals.

Sleep now, little Polo.

The end. ■